Princess Fatima Parahiman

Atty. Princess Fatima T. Parahiman is a Maranao lawyer from Masiu, Lanao del Sur who made history by placing 2nd in the 2019 Philippine Bar Examinations, earning a rating of 89.523%.

She is recognized as the second female Bangsamoro lawyer to break into the Top 10 of the Philippine Bar Examinations, following the pioneering achievement of Judge Mylene Amerol-Macumbal in 2008.<ref name="bangsamoro_parliament">Bangsamoro Parliament Resolution No. 71, formally commending Atty. Princess Fatima T. Parahiman for her achievement in the 2019 Philippine Bar Examinations.</ref>

Her historic placement came at a defining moment: the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) was still in its earliest years, and Parahiman's success gave the region something tangible and undeniable to point to, a Maranao woman from Lanao del Sur competing at the very top of the country's most demanding professional examination and winning.

To the Bangsamoro people, she isn't just a topnotcher. She's proof.

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Atty. Princess Fatima T. Parahiman



Birthplace	Masiu, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity	Maranao
Education	University of the Philippines Diliman (B.S. Economics, *Cum Laude*); University of the East College of Law (Juris Doctor, Valedictorian)
Known for	2nd Place, 2019 Philippine Bar Examinations
Distinction	Second female Bangsamoro bar topnotcher in Philippine history
Bar Rating	89.523%

Early Life and Background

Parahiman grew up in Masiu, Lanao del Sur, a municipality situated along the shores of Lake Lanao in the heart of Maranao country.

The Maranao are one of the major Muslim ethno-linguistic groups in the Philippines, known for a deep cultural code called *Maratabat*, which carries ideas of honor, dignity, and collective pride. Growing up within that tradition meant that Parahiman's personal achievements were always understood to carry weight beyond herself, that what she accomplished reflected on her family, her community, and her faith.

Lanao del Sur, for all its cultural richness, has lived through decades of conflict, displacement, and underinvestment. Against that backdrop, pursuing higher education at the country's most competitive universities was not a small decision. It was a deliberate, sustained act of faith in what was possible.

That combination of cultural rootedness and personal determination would follow her through every stage of her academic and professional life.

Education

University of the Philippines Diliman

Parahiman took her undergraduate degree at the University of the Philippines Diliman, the country's national university and one of its most academically rigorous institutions.

She graduated *Cum Laude* with a degree in Economics, a discipline that gave her a structured way to understand the systemic forces shaping communities like her own.<ref name="ue_profile">University of the East College of Law records and publications on Atty. Princess Fatima T. Parahiman's academic distinctions.</ref>

Economics isn't a typical pre-law path, and that choice reveals something important about how she thinks. She came into law not just as an advocate for individuals, but as someone who'd already spent years examining how institutions work, and fail, and can be made to work better.

University of the East College of Law

For her Juris Doctor, Parahiman enrolled at the University of the East College of Law in Manila.

She didn't just survive law school. She led it. She graduated as Class Valedictorian, finishing at the top of her class in a program that demands everything from its students.<ref name="ue_profile"/>

Her peers knew her as someone with quiet strength, someone who carried the pressures of law school with steadiness and was active in the law student government. That combination of academic excellence and genuine engagement with her community would become characteristic of everything she did after graduation.

The 2019 Philippine Bar Examinations

Results and National Standing

The results of the 2019 Philippine Bar Examinations were officially released in April 2020. Out of 7,685 examinees who sat for the exams, Parahiman placed 2nd nationally with a rating of 89.523%.<ref name="sc_results">Supreme Court of the Philippines, Official Results of the 2019 Bar Examinations, released April 2020.</ref>

That's a remarkable number under any circumstances. The Philippine Bar is notoriously difficult, and the exam tests candidates across multiple subjects over several Sundays. Placing in the Top 10 requires not just intelligence but months of total commitment, and doing it while maintaining her cultural and religious identity as a Hijabi Muslim woman from Mindanao added dimensions to her achievement that numbers alone can't fully capture.

Historical Significance

Parahiman's 2nd place finish made her the second female Bangsamoro bar topnotcher in Philippine history, following Judge Mylene Amerol-Macumbal, who placed in the Top 10 of the 2008 Philippine Bar Examinations. <ref name="bangsamoro_parliament"/>

More than a decade had passed between Amerol-Macumbal's milestone and Parahiman's. The gap itself is part of the story: Muslim Filipino women had been largely invisible in national narratives of legal excellence, and Parahiman's placement brought that conversation back, loudly.

In a field dominated by graduates of Manila-based law schools and examinees from Luzon, her success reframed what the Philippine legal community looks like and where its talent comes from.

Humility as a Public Statement

What came after the results were announced was almost as significant as the results themselves.

Parahiman spoke publicly about her experience of *Tawakkul*, the Islamic concept of surrendering one's outcomes to God after doing one's best. She shared that she had dreamed she failed the exams, and that her journey through that fear, and the relief on the other side, was inseparable from her faith.

> That moment of vulnerability connected her to thousands of bar examinees across the country who had also sat in fear, also prayed, and also hoped. She wasn't performing humility; she was living it out loud.

In a culture that often treats topnotchers as superhuman, Parahiman made herself relatable. And in doing so, she became a more powerful symbol, not just of excellence, but of what it looks like to pursue excellence while remaining fully yourself.

Recognition and Honors

Bangsamoro Parliament Resolution No. 71

The Bangsamoro Parliament passed Resolution No. 71 formally commending Atty. Princess Fatima T. Parahiman for her historic placement in the 2019 Bar Examinations.<ref name="bangsamoro_parliament"/>

The resolution described her success as a "beacon of hope" for the youth of the BARMM, and called on the Bangsamoro community to take inspiration from her example.

It was a rare moment of formal institutional recognition for an individual achievement, and it underscored how seriously the Bangsamoro government understood the symbolic weight of what she had accomplished.

Cultural Honors

Within Maranao communities, Parahiman has been honored with the title *Bae a Labi*, a designation for noble women of distinction whose conduct and achievement bring honor to their lineage and their people.

The title isn't handed out lightly. It speaks to a communal recognition that she hasn't just done well for herself; she has carried something forward for the community.

Cultural and Social Significance

A Symbol for the BARMM

Parahiman's achievement landed at a historically significant moment. The Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao was established in 2019 under the Bangsamoro Organic Law, replacing the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM). The region was, in its truest sense, just beginning.

Her bar placement offered early evidence that the Bangsamoro's human capital was not just competitive at the regional level, but at the national level. She became, without ever seeking the role, a kind of living argument for what the region could produce when its people were given the chance to compete on equal footing.

Representation for Muslim Filipino Women

As a practicing Muslim who wore the hijab throughout her academic career and into her professional life, Parahiman also represented something important for young Muslim Filipino women who often feel the pressure to choose between their faith identity and their professional ambitions.

She didn't choose. She brought both with her, all the way to 2nd place on the national bar.

That visibility matters. Young women across Lanao del Sur, Maguindanao, Tawi-Tawi, and the wider Bangsamoro region saw someone who looked like them, prayed like them, and dressed like them achieving something that the whole country was talking about.

Legacy

Parahiman's legacy is still being written.

She belongs to a lineage of Bangsamoro women who have pushed into spaces where they were not expected and did not simply survive those spaces but reshaped them. She follows Judge Mylene Amerol-Macumbal and stands now as a reference point herself, the person that future Bangsamoro lawyers will look back at when they need a reason to believe the distance is crossable.

Her story carries a quiet insistence: that excellence and identity are not in conflict, that you can be Maranao, Muslim, and a woman, and still stand at the top of Philippine legal achievement. Not despite those things, but as those things.

The Bangsamoro region has a phrase that captures this well. *Mastura a Ranao*, the beautiful lake, has always produced people of depth and resilience. Parahiman is one of them, and she's shown that depth has no ceiling.

See Also

- Mylene Amerol-Macumbal
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Philippine Bar Examinations
- Maranao people
- Maratabat
- University of the East College of Law
- University of the Philippines Diliman
- Bangsamoro Parliament
- Lanao del Sur

Further Reading

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